CONGRESS

NEW RESOLUTION, OLD CONGRESS

By Kaushik Deka

On May 16, a day after the Congress ended its three-day-long Nav Sankalp Shivir in Udaipur, the party witnessed a formal gesture. T.N. Prathapan resigned from a post he had been holding since 2017—that of national chairman, the All India Fishermen Congress. He did so in accordance with the letter and spirit of the Udaipur resolution, which, among other things, declared that no person in the party would hold the same position for more than five years. The key question now is: will other stalwarts in the party voluntarily walk the talk when it comes to organisational reforms?

That there is an urgent need to make key alterations in the party's organisational structure if it has to find a road to revival was acknowledged by Congress president Sonia Gandhi herself. The "most immediately relevant" resolutions are related to organisational reforms, she said in her concluding speech. But the heads of several departments of the party have been occupying the positions for more than five years—take communication, law, research and the professional Congress. In his own words, Mukul Wasnik has been a general secretary for over two decades. Will we see everyone acting in concord with Prathapan's gesture?

At Udaipur, the party also made a few other radical decisions. A new layer has been created in the organisation: mandal committees, which will be placed between the level of the booth and that of blocks. The performance of every officer-bearer, from the booth to the Congress Working Committee (CWC), the highest decision-making body, will be evaluated. "General secretaries will be given specific tasks and the organisational general secretary will evaluate them based on their performance," said Ajay Maken, two days after the Udaipur resolution.

In every committee of the Congress, from the booth upwards to the CWC, 50 per cent of the members will be under the age of 50. Only one member from a family can get tickets. The second person must spend at least five years in organisational work to earn the right to get a ticket. To drive the processes of internal reforms, the party will form a compact task force.

These changes will be crucial for the successful implementation of the party's political agenda, as set out at Udaipur. With the slogan of "'Bharat Jodo", the Grand Old Party resolved to fight the ruling BJP by offering a new narrative. It will go for a nationwide *padayatra* to fight back against the BJP's politics of division, poor handling of the economy and indifference towards the socially and economically backward, women, farmers and youth, the resolution said.

But to take its narrative to the masses, the task force must deliver on reforms. The party already has an excuse to buy time till September as organisational elections are going on. Some of the proposed moves are



A NEW THOUGHT PROCESS?
Sonia-Rahul with other Congress leaders in Udaipur